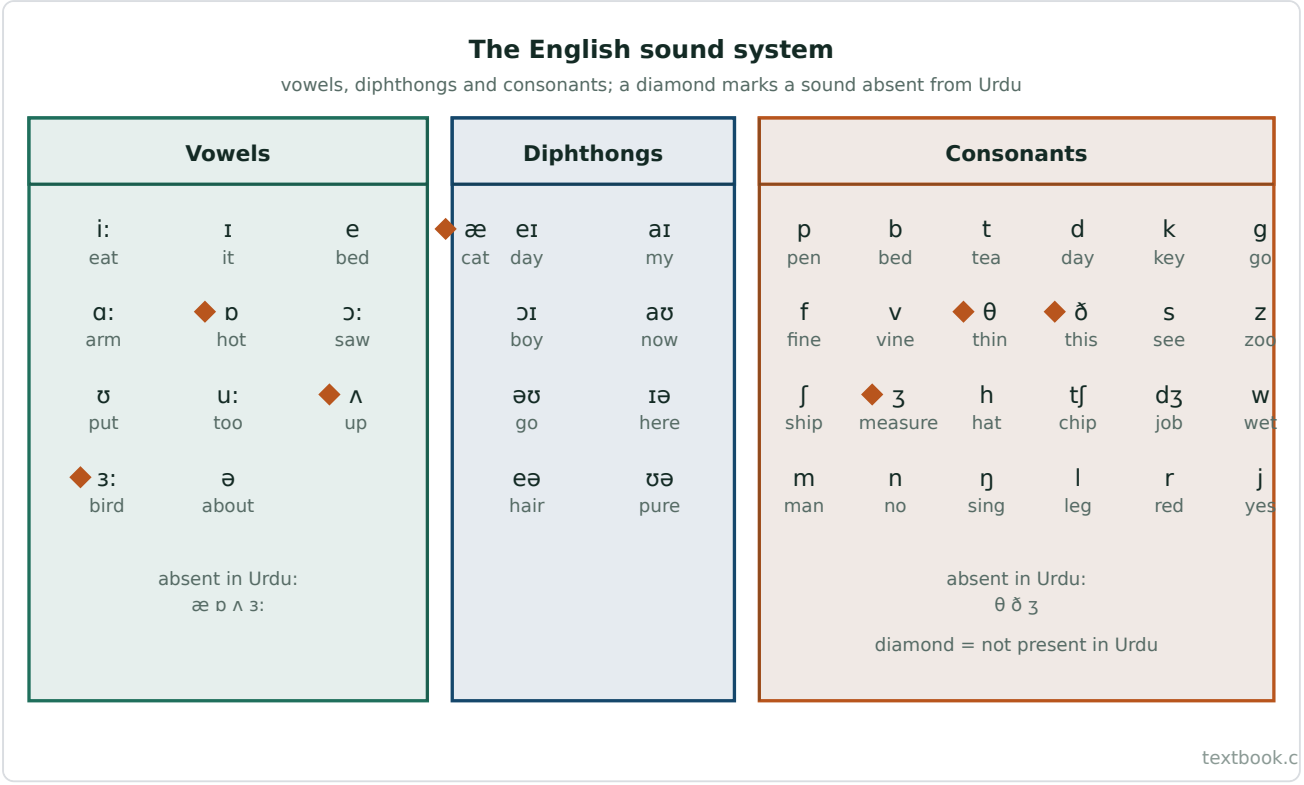
Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Topic 1.3 - Sounds of English

A real classroom situation



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Miss Hina teaches Class 6 English in a government school in Islamabad. She asks her pupils to pronounce "think". Several pupils say "tink". She asks them to pronounce "this". Several say "dis". She asks them to pronounce "vet". Several say "wet". This topic is about why these errors happen and what to do about them.

Explanation

English has approximately 44 sounds (phonemes) but only 26 letters. This means that the relationship between spelling and sound is not one-to-one. For Urdu speakers, the challenge is greater because English has sounds that do not exist in Urdu, and Urdu has sounds that do not exist in English.

The English sound system

Pronunciation challenges for Urdu speakers

the challenge, the common error and a practice strategy

Challenge	Urdu-influenced error	Correct sound and strategy
th sounds voice and no voice	thin said as tin this said as dis	tongue between the teeth breathe out for thin, hum for this
v / w both become one	vine said as wine wine said as vine	v: teeth on the lower lip w: round the lips, no touch
p / f often swapped	park said as fark food said as pood	p: pop air through the lips f: bite the lower lip, blow
final clusters end consonants dropped	desk said as des asked said as ask-ed	say the full cluster slowly then speed up to a natural pace
vowel length long and short merge	ship and sheep sound the same full and fool sound the same	long vowel: stretch the sound short vowel: cut it short
stress patterns even weight on syllables	PHOtoGRAPH stress on every part	one syllable carries the beat PHOtograph, phoTOGraphy

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The figure above maps the main categories of English sounds and the challenges they pose for Urdu speakers.

Vowels. English has twelve vowel sounds (monophthongs) and eight diphthongs (two vowel sounds blended together in one syllable). Urdu has far fewer vowel sounds, which is why distinctions like "ship/sheep", "full/fool" and "cat/cut" are difficult. The figure above maps the most problematic distinctions.

Consonants. English has 24 consonant sounds. Several do not exist in Urdu: the "th" sounds in "think" and "this", the "v" sound in "vet", the "w" sound in "wet", and the "zh" sound in "measure". Urdu speakers often substitute the closest Urdu sound: "t" for "th", "f" for "v", "w" for "v" (sometimes in the wrong direction).

Stress. In English, every word of more than one syllable has one syllable that is stressed (louder, longer, higher in pitch). "REcord" (noun) and "reCORD" (verb) are distinguished only by stress. Urdu stress patterns are different, which can make Pakistani English sound flat to a native speaker.

Intonation is the rise and fall of the voice across a phrase or sentence. English uses intonation to distinguish statements from questions, to show emphasis, and to signal attitude. Urdu intonation patterns are different, and direct transfer can produce speech that sounds uninterested or rude when no rudeness is intended.

Common challenges for Urdu speakers

The figure above maps the most common pronunciation challenges. The most frequent are:

- **"th" sounds** (think, this, bath, bathe): Urdu has no equivalent; speakers substitute "t/d" or "s/z".
- **"v" and "w" distinction** (vet/wet, very/well): Urdu has a sound between the two; speakers confuse them.
- **"p" and "f" distinction** (pin/fin, pat/fat): Some Urdu dialects merge these sounds.
- **Final consonant clusters** (desks, texts, films): Urdu does not allow clusters at the end of syllables; speakers insert vowels ("deskes").
- **Vowel length** (ship/sheep, full/fool): Urdu does not distinguish these pairs.

Common misconception. "Pronunciation does not matter as long as people understand you." It does matter. Poor pronunciation can cause misunderstanding, and in professional contexts it can affect how competent you sound. The goal is not a British or American accent but clarity.

Activity: Minimal pairs practice

Work in pairs. Take the following minimal pairs (pairs of words that differ by one sound). One partner says one word from a pair; the other identifies which word was said. Then switch.

Pair 1	Pair 2	Pair 3	Pair 4	Pair 5
ship / sheep	vet / wet	think / sink	full / fool	pin / fin
bat / bet	this / dis	bad / bed	cat / cut	fan / van

Allow 15 minutes. Then discuss: which pairs were hardest to distinguish? What strategy helped?

Check your understanding

1. Explain why English has more sounds than letters, and give one example. *(Understand)*
2. A pupil says "tink" for "think". Identify the sound that is causing the difficulty and explain why it is difficult for Urdu speakers. *(Analyze)*
3. Explain the difference between stress and intonation, and give one example of each. *(Remember)*
4. Write three minimal pairs that would help a Urdu speaker practise the "v/w" distinction. *(Apply)*
5. A friend says, "I just speak loudly and they will understand." Using this topic's account, explain why volume is not the same as clarity. *(Evaluate)*

Summary

English has approximately 44 phonemes, several of which do not exist in Urdu. The most common challenges for Urdu speakers are the "th" sounds, the "v/w" distinction, final consonant clusters and vowel length. Stress and intonation are as important as individual sounds. The goal is clarity, not a native-speaker accent.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can explain why English has more sounds than letters.

- [ ] I can identify the pronunciation challenges most common among Urdu speakers.
- [ ] I can explain the difference between stress and intonation.
- [ ] I can create minimal pairs for practising difficult sound distinctions.
- [ ] I can explain why clarity matters more than accent.

Try this at your practicum school

Record (with permission) two minutes of a teacher reading an English text aloud. Identify five pronunciation features that might cause difficulty for pupils: sounds that do not exist in Urdu, stress patterns that are different from Urdu, or intonation patterns that might confuse. Write half a page on your findings and suggest one strategy the teacher could use to address each feature.

Summative task

Write 300 to 350 words on the following.

> A pupil in your practicum school consistently pronounces "ship" and "sheep" the same way, and says "tink" for "think". Using this topic's account of the English sound system, explain why these errors happen, identify the specific sounds involved, and propose three specific strategies the pupil could use to improve.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Explanation of the errors (Understand)	Identifies the specific phonemes that do not exist in Urdu
Identification of the sounds (Analyze)	Names the sounds (/ɪ/ vs /iː/, /θ/ vs /t/) and explains the difficulty
Proposed strategies (Apply)	**Proposes three specific, practicable strategies, not generic advice**

Criterion	What a strong response does
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Swan, M. *Practical English Usage.* (guide recommended)
- Azar, B. S. *Understanding and Using English Grammar.* (guide recommended)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback